sympathetically, but said she would not tolerate illegal street vending.

The sudden call to arms against hawkers/ small shop-owners who have encroached on government land—that too by a bona fide champion of the marginalised—stems from concerning news for the TMC. On June 4, after the Lok Sabha election results were declared, Indian Political Action Committee (I-PAC)—the TMC's poll strategist—conveyed a message. While the TMC had wrested 29 of the 42 Lok Sabha seats in the state, most of its support came from rural areas. In civic areas, the BJP got more votes than the TMC in at least 70 of the 128 urban bodies. Under the Kolkata Municipal Corporation itself, the BJP prevailed over the TMC in 44 of the 145 wards. What's more, the saffron camp defeated the TMC in six of the nine wards that fall under Kolkata's Bhabanipur assembly constituency, which Mamata herself represents.

ANI



RIGHT DIRECTION
Mamata Banerjee has asked district administrations to stop encroachment on government land

According to TMC sources, Mamata has two objectives. Firstly, by publicly calling out law enforcers from her party for being "corrupt", she is distancing herself from dishonest partymen. That's meant to neutralise the Opposition's charge of widespread corruption against the TMC that had clearly succeeded in fashioning a potent weapon out of anti-incumbency. Secondly, she is establishing an image that her administration will go to any length to secure the rights of the urban electorate. "The depletion in our urban support is significant. Almost half of our cabinet is from the Kolkata Dakshin parliamentary segment. Yet, we are behind the BJP in 20 of the 59 KMC wards here," says a TMC source. "If we don't make amends, we will suffer in the 2026 assembly polls." He adds that the push behind the drive comes from Mamata's nephew and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee.

Abhishek reportedly believes that the party has had to bear the brunt of anti-incumbency because several government departments function poorly. He wants Mamata to clean the Augean stables before the long-pending elections in two corporations and 13 municipalities are declared.

> **"Encroachment is the biggest problem. Some people are allowing this for money. Bengal's identity is being altered because you are taking money"**
>
> **MAMATA BANERJEE**
> *Chief Minister, West Bengal*

The jury is still out, though, on whether formal action would be taken against the TMC members whom Mamata accused of illegal practices. "The CM has admitted that her colleagues allow illegal encroachment through corrupt means. But will there be any action against them, like the crackdown on hawkers?" asks political analyst Subhamoy Maitra.

Sources in the administration say that fierce political resistance—a regular feature in Bengal whenever action has sought to be taken against illegal encroachment—has been absent due to Mamata's directive. But some officers say that the crackdown is an 'eyewash' and that the practice of installing illegal hawkers in exchange of money will return. During the June 24 meeting, Mamata came down heavily on Amrita Burman Roy, the sub-divisional officer of Howrah city, whom she accused of being a non-performer. Roy, who was appointed by the Election Commission, has been in office for two months; her seniors say she is a capable officer. "We are worried that if things go out of hand, administrative officers will be made scapegoats," says a senior IAS officer.

Multiple civic bodies, including those of Kolkata and Howrah, are preparing operating procedures to remove illegal hawkers and rehabilitate legal ones. However, leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari of the BJP has accused Mamata herself of encroaching upon land near her Kolkata home to expand the office in her residence. "You are unhappy as BJP has won in various municipalities," he said at a news conference. Pointing out that numerous people come to Kolkata and earn their livelihood as hawkers, he said, "I would urge Mamata Banerjee to...make a clear SoP, give them alternate livelihood and then remove their stalls. We will stand by these people." ■